It Takes a Village to Raise a Child (It Takes a Teacher to Save Them)

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Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Category:
M/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
George/Lance (She-Ra), Adora & Lance (She-Ra), Lance & Catra (She-Ra), Lance & Lonnie (She-Ra), Lance & Kyle (She-Ra), Lance & Rogelio (She-Ra), Adora & Catra & Kyle & Lonnie & Rogelio (She-Ra), Kyle & Lonnie & Rogelio (She-ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

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Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Teacher Lance (She-Ra), Wrongful Imprisonment, Life in the Horde (She-Ra), Warning: Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), off-screen death of a child, Implied/Referenced Character Death, Starvation, Humor, Acts of Kindness, Inspired by Discord

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by Utter_Immolation

Summary

When Lance is captured by the Horde, he is offered the opportunity to work off his "crimes" by teaching reading and writing to two dozen young Horde cadets.

Or

The Teacher!Lance AU

Notes

Warning: off-screen death of child(ren).

See the end of the work for more notes

Lance had always been considered lucky. He had a beautiful home, a handsome husband, delightful children. So yes, he was considered lucky.

So, with that in mind, considering what could have been, his luck was still apparently intact in some shape or form

After all, he'd seen the homes burning, the way people fell and didn't get up again. Heard the matching goosestep and the screams of parents desperately trying to hold on as their children were ripped from their arms. The sounds and images haunted him, but at least he'd barely been hurt as they shackled him to a dozen others and marched them through the wasteland.

At least none of his children, safe at home and watched over by the eldest, were one of the terrified souls bundled onto skiffs and brought to the heart of the terrifying Fright Zone that loomed ahead.

He prayed that George was okay. He prayed that he'd see his children again. And then he straightened his back and locked those wishes away into his soul because even he knew that dreams didn't come true in the Horde.

He spent a month in prison.

They beat him about, though not as much as the ones that screamed and fought. Those they bashed to the ground with brutal strikes and crackling batons until they could only whimper. The ones that didn't stop were dragged away and Lance knew he'd never see them again.

No, mostly they'd cuffed him about in an attempt to get a confession out of him. It didn't matter too much: the interrogators were clearly bored, and he clearly wasn't he wasn't a troublemaker, let alone a fighter. And everyone in that room knew it really didn't matter in the end.

He quietly told them of his (now former) occupation as a librarian, historian and teacher, accepted the shoves and punches, and settled down in his cell with a daily ration of the most disgusting brown bar he'd ever had the misfortune to call food for four long weeks, raking his shorne head with trembling fingers. He knew release was off the table, and if they were going to torture him, surely it would have happened by now? No, all he could hope was that they gave him some janitorial task or something similar, and didn't decide to have him sent to the mines to waste away.

Five weeks into his imprisonment he was pulled out of his cell. At first he felt a bit of hope that they weren't dragging out to the desert, to the mines or perhaps, an execution. And then as he dared to peek about, his heart plummeted as he realized he was being escorted to the central tower. And if he was a tyrant bent on world domination…then…

His heart seized with terror and he scarcely noticed the crumbling halls, rusted halls alight with sickly green and the looming twisted pipes and exposed bundles of cable, of the soldiers that jeered at him as he and his escort passed. He barely noticed a thing until he was harshly thrown to the ground with a hissed "Kneel!"

He stayed on his aching knees, but couldn't help the way his gaze lifted, traveling up the dais, up the trailing Cape and past armored boots, skirting over the surprisingly narrow chest plate to take in the pale face and the blood red eyes boring into him.

This was Hordak, the Lord of the Horde, the Scourge of the Kingdoms, the…the…

"Rebel. You are in luck. Your transgressions—"

"I'm sorry—" Lance starts.

"—have been considered, and in my mercy—"

"—what species are *you* ?"

Lance gets a hard boot to the side that knocks the wind out of him. He lay, gasping from the shock of the blow, as one of the soldiers that escorted him raised their baton, both man and weapon crackling with fury. "HOW DARE—"

"SILENCE!"

The soldiers snapped to attention even as Lance rolled back to his knees, blatantly examining the Horde Lord. Okay, that hadn't been his smartest idea, but how could he resist? The Horde Lord, Hordak, had never disclosed his species type, or his parents, or really anything about his origins, and Lance couldn't even begin to guess the possible evolutionary traits he had or who what type of hybrid his parents possibly could have been—

Oh. Oops. The man…creature…Hordak was speaking.

"—found ourselves in need of a relatively competent being capable of instructing cadets on the rudimentary skills of life—"

"What kind of skills?" Lance blurted out, then winced as the soldiers behind him shuffled and Hordak's fist clenched.

"Reading," the warlord gritted through his fangs. "Writing. Mayhaps history. *True* history, not the sanitized falsehoods your precious Princesses tout."

Oof. Lance was glad, not for the first time, that George wasn't there, because he would have had something to say, soldier's discipline or no, about being accused of having "precious

Princesses". And "true history"? All history was biased, but Lance had a feeling the Horde's was a bit more exaggerated than usual.

"You will be closely watched. Any betrayal of my generosity will see you…removed. Am I clear?"

"Um…ahem. Yes, sir." When the warlord raised a brow of warning, Lance quickly amended his response, even as it burned his heart and soul to say: "Yes, my Lord."

"Serve me well, bring glory to the Horde, and when order has been brought to this planet, your sentence will be reexamined."

The war had been going on for over a decade now. Even if the Horde won, even if he were to survive that long, would he even be able to look at himself in the mirror?

No. No he would not.

He looked over the classroom with ill-concealed horror at the two dozen small—too, too small—faces gazing back at him. He thinks about his own children doing the same, thinks about Dirk or Axe or Bow (oh stars, *Bow*) and wants to vomit.

The silence stretches as he stares, frozen, until one of his guards, sitting in the back of the classroom (and what a classroom: metal tables, dim lighting, no windows and not a book in sight) gives a pointed clearing of their throat.

Lance swallows his grief and plasters the best smile he can at the children. It feels wobbly and probably looks as sickly as he feels, but given the surprised and curious head tilts he received, it's probably serviceable. "Good morning, chi—cadets. I am" Assistant, Doctor, Professor. "Instructor Lance. Let's begin."

Lance quickly realizes that there are two groups in his class of twenty-five: the children under Shadow Weaver's direct control and everybody else.

The group of five, Squad D1, alternates between being close-knit and downright vicious to each other on a dime and much of that has to do with the squad's unofficial leader: Adora.

Even with her gap toothed grin and guileless blue eyes, it's clear the squad revolves about her, much to their own pride and resentment. More than once he's had Shadow Weaver lurking outside his door during a lesson, only to snatch up the girl the second it's over, alternating between slathering pride and blistering criticism so quickly and smoothly, it leaves even the eavesdropping Lance dizzy, to say nothing of how it must affect the girl. And this treatment trickles down to the rest of the squad. Shadow Weaver uses the child like a mouthpiece, essentially grooming Adora to regurgitate her offhanded toxicity. And to

make matters worse, despite being *her* responsibility, the witch essentially pushes the girl into acting as a sort of pseudo-parent which goes about as well as you'd think.

This of course means passionate Lonnie alternates between grudging respect for Adora's physical prowess and seething anger as she, Rogelio and Kyle are all but ignored by the person who is supposedly their direct supervisor. And Rogelio—he needed help, twisted vocal cords rendering him unable to speak Common and of course, the Horde had no material or interest in Etherian Signing Standard. And Kyle was bright, so bright, and clever, but rarely was allowed to shine, as the Horde encouraged a sort of ritualistic inner-squad hazing and Kyle, already showcasing a nervous demeanor and failing to achieve "mass standards" was the target of vicious cruelty every moment of every single day.

And Catra…

Oh, Catra.

Lance was rarely angry. That had never been a part of his everyday demeanor, and he'd never seen it as productive. But Catra…

The girl was bright, brilliant, and Lance saw the way she reached for Adora, saw the way the girl reached back, saw the way how, just for a moment, Catra's surly glare would soften and Adora furrowed brow would smooth, and watched the witch take the girl aside constantly and she'd reappear days later still stinking of ash and ozone, teeth bared and shoulders hunched.

To his shame, he almost lets it slide. Almost lets himself ignore it, lets himself be yet another adult who should know better, should be braver, and still turns away, focused on his own survival in this toxic pit.

But Shadow Weaver corners him a month into his servitude, dismissing his guard who scuttles away under the threat of her sickly shadows and glowing gem. "I believe, Rebel," she sneers, "you made an error on one of your cadet's tests. You will correct it post-haste."

Lance blinks at her, baffled at the abrupt appearance and her equally abrupt conversation start. "I…apologize? Which student was it?"

" *Adora* ."

A part of him, barely kept in check, recoils at the way Shadow Weaver almost *caresses* his student's name on her tongue. Like she was a valued possession and not a person. He'd heard George purr less over his favorite wine.

(Oh, his love. Oh, George. He missed him, missed his scent, his voice, his embrace. The other day he'd almost had a breakdown when he tried to sketch his husband's face on a spare sheet of paper and couldn't get the angles quite right.)

(He doesn't want to forget.)

(He doesn't think he could bear it.)

"Ah, yes Adora. If I recall she's been having issues on the writing portion of our assessments. I noticed—"

The shadows pulsed. The hall grew cold. The witch's robes seem to stretch, her mask suddenly looming over her.

" *Silence!* I don't need your opinion. It was not a *request* . I will not have Adora's future besmirched by your lies!"

And if Lance was of weaker spirit he would have acquiesced. If he was more cowardly, he would have agreed on the spot.

But Lance was a stubborn man: he'd trawled through the dustiest tomes to prove theories others had laughed at, had painstakingly excavated artifacts of the ancients, had agreed to raise thirteen sons in the midst of the Whispering Woods. He was a historian, a teacher, and a father.

And it was this man who straightened his spine and glared up through the darkness at the mask gazing cruelly down upon him and said, "I will not."

The only warning he gets is the smell of ozone and the prickle of his hair rising before the darkness flashes and everything goes black.

He awakes in the closet that is his quarters. He's been laid haphazardly upon his bunk. His uniform is stiff and clinging and stinking where he voided his bowels. His finger and toes tingle and his tongue feels too big for his mouth. He nearly collapses when he tries to stand, his legs practically numb from his ordeal, and barely catches himself on the bunk post.

It takes him nearly fifteen minutes to gather his thoughts and coordination enough to stagger over to the tiny, rusted sink embedded in the wall, fumble with the handle and shakily splash the icy, metallic water over his face and cup somethin his hands to lap with his clumsy tongue.

He thinks he should feel some sort of horror or terror from what happened. Should be shaking over the fact that someone could have killed him with but a thought. Instead, all he feels is hot anger and righteous indignation.

It fuels him as he shakily marches to his door. He should be resting. Instead he was going to do something he should have done from the beginning: research.

Adora had dyslexia.

Or, rather, that's the best rudimentary conclusion Lance can come up with as he peruses the medley of barely organized files of his student's past assignments and assessments. Of course the physical and medical files were far more organized, he bitterly notes—education was hardly needed to hold a baton was it?

When it came to Adora, a cursory glance presented an excellent, hardworking student. Having seen her in class, Lance didn't doubt the picture being painted was relatively true. *Relatively* . It didn't take long to see the cracks in the illusion.

Adora's papers, while detailed to the best of her extent, were riddled with misspelled words, incorrect letter placement and in some cases, letters in words completely replaced with strange, placeholder symbols and lines.

The troubling part was the near lack of correction or aid on her assignments. Sure, early pieces had been streaked in red ink but it was easy to see the pattern that emerged—as she grew, Adora's teachers became quick to heap praise and quick, lazy full marks upon her sheets, with nary a suggestion or correction to be seen. Those who had tried to give aid swiftly changed their tune, the red disappearing often entirely.

It didn't take a genius to guess why.

In contrast, Catra's papers were practically stained with red, with heavy marks and deductions received for everything from a misplaced comma to tiny nicks in the paper from the girl's claws. Despite all of these, while her work wasn't flawless, there was actually little that merited the near vitriolic criticism from her instructors.

Little…if you didn't factor in the *witch* .

This pattern seemed to follow with the rest of the squad of D1: while everyone seemed quite bright, creative and perceptive, when it came to Lonnie, Rogelio and Kyle, their former instructors, while not as deliberate biased as they were with their lone magicat student, the other three tended to still get weigh in such a way as to ensure that, while not far behind, their scores still fell behind that of their leader's. Rogelio seemed to have a problem taking notes and had notes in his file for "cheating". Lance recalled the way the lizardkin tended to lean forward, squinting at the board and had a feeling that cheating had never crossed the boy's mind.

And Kyle's…It took Lance a while to figure out what was niggling at him. The boy's answers were often wrong, but he knew the boy was quite quick on the uptake and grasped the concepts far quicker than one would think. By all accounts, his homework scores, when adjusted for his former teacher's falsehoods, were near exemplary. So how did he get so many wrong on the major tests themselves?

He wouldn't…unless he was doing so deliberately.

Oh, it wasn't enough to completely fail him, and he still did get an understandable amount incorrect, but the rest…some of the wrong answers were *too obvious* , their pattern *too neat* .

Was it due to his knowing about his teacher's deliberate scaling? Or something else? The hazing perhaps?

Was it easier for him, a proposed loser, to already present the image of a failure than try and risk ridicule for succeeding?

It wasn't just D1. The files were rife with lazy, half-hearted instructor notes and riddled with little issues that may have been easy to dismiss but painted damning pictures of neglect. Hunt the fishkin had trouble reading. Krom the humankin had difficulty following verbal instruction. Yeton the hybrid had hyperactivity. On and on and on. A collage of adults failing children.

Of course they were. No worthy adult pressed weapons into small hands and told the child to still be grateful.

By all accounts, whatever he did was meaningless in the long run. He had his student an hour a day, thrice a week and what was his voice to the brutal bellows and howls that followed them from dawn to dusk?

The air was fragrant with pine and dew. They stood, their feet bare, as little Dirk, on his knees with cheeks blotched with tears, patted and smoothed the little mound of freshly turned earth. He'd scarcely finished before he plopped on his bottom, reedy cries erupting from his throat. Lance and George knelt, wrapping their arms around the sobbing boy.

After a while, clinging to his father's embraces, Dirk's wails softened to whimpers. "Why—why'd she hafta die?"

"Oh, honey," George murmured. "The kitty was really sick, remember? She didn't have much time left."

Dirk's eyes sprang fresh tears. "Then—then what was th'point?! We helped and helped and it didn't do anything!"

"That's not true, Dirkkie," Lance whispered. "We let her pass in as much comfort as we could provide, nice and warm."

"But she still died!"

The husbands exchanged a glance over their son's head and George let Lance take the lead with a small nod. "Yes, she did. Some parts of life…you can't stop. You can only delay. But Dirk the important thing is this: just because you don't get the results you want, doesn't mean it's meaningless to do good. When a good person does nothing, evil wins."

George kissed Dirk's brow, Lance's lips. "Even when it seems hopeless, take a stand. Take a stand not for pride, or reward. Take a stand because sometimes, someone has to."

Lance looks around scattered pages of a tragedy and grits his teeth, his mind whiling with possibilities.

"If not me, then who?"

But—how? The witch would never allow…

Well.

There was one way.

"Why is this my concern, Rebel? This is your task, not mine."

"With all due respect…Lord Hordak. I require further material to develop the chil—cadet's capabilities the best I can. And, and! While it may be considered contraband material on the contrary, it will provide invaluable insight into the minds of your enemies.

Some of these books are even considered controversial amongst the monarchy and loyalists, as they fester social discord."

"My Lord, this is preposterous—!"

"Silence, Weaver…Librarian. You believe these…texts will provide psychological understanding of the Rebellion leaders and Loyalists? And aid their education development as well?"

"I do, my Lord."

"...humpth. We will see. "

"My Lo—"

"ENOUGH! Shadow Weaver, provide the Rebel with his…material."

"Yes…my Lord."

"Class, we are reworking the entire curriculum. We're still waiting on material, but we will begin reading and developing reports on the texts we do have. We're limited so at the moment you will

share with your squad. We're going to take turns reading aloud as well, so make sure everyone in your squad can see! Kyle? Would you like to begin?"

"U-uhm. Uh…ahem. 'I-it is a truth uni…universally acknowledged, that a single man in po…ssess…ion of a good fortune…must be in want of a wife'…"

Lance takes a lot of notes that first week.

Kyle proves to be a great orator. They take turns reading a paragraph at a time, and by the third class Kyle is reading aloud with a confident sort of relish. The sniggers when he stutters haven't stopped, but the boy seemed to have an easier time ignoring them, especially when the perpetrators found themselves subject to Lance's full attention.

Quite unfortunately, part of this seems to be because Adora has incredible difficulty with many of the words she's made to read. Lance patiently guides her through the tricky parts but she still flushes with embarrassment and hunches in her seat, no matter how often Catra flicks her tail against her back in encouragement. To her credit, Adora is quick to return the favor, pressing even more against her, even as their squad is crammed practically atop each other to see the book, beaming at her even as her ears pin back every time her larynx ripples and disrupts her reading with half-strangled "mrrps".

It's a bit harder with Rogelio. His inability to vocalize means the vast majority of classmates are unable to actually understand him. Still, Lance doesn't let that deter anyone. Rogelio reads his paragraphs in throaty snarls, growls and hisses, and the class follows along. Still, it could be better and Lance hopes the inventory specialists are able to procure one of the material books he requested sooner than later.

They spend half a class on a chapter, the rest of the class discussing it, and he assigns a report to be due the next class.

The results of this are twenty-two papers of varying quality, and two missing ones: one, belonging to Jint, who'd forgotten, and the other one belonging to—

"Kyle. Catra. What happened today?"

Kyle shuffled his feet, sneaking sideways at his magicat teammate and quailing at the venom in her gaze.

"I turned it in," Catra grumbled.

Lance raised a brow and looked at Kyle.

His shoulders were hunched, seemingly trying to sink as far into his own skin as he could. "I lost it," he finally whispered.

Lance barely resisted closing his eyes to stave off the looming headache. "Kyle. This is your handwriting. Catra. The only thing that makes this yours is the fact that you crossed out your squadmate's name and wrote your own."

Catra scowled, her hands flexing but said nothing when Lance once again raised his brow.

"Kyle, I'll have this filed under your name. Dismissed. Catra, please stay."

The blond boy fled without a second glance, and Lance was left alone with a surly magicat. He opened his mouth and paused. Looming over his sons when he was trying to coax answers from them had never helped then, and he doubted it would help now.

He stood and started to come around the desk then stopped as Catra's entire body gave a minute flinch, the fur ruffling in quickly suppressed agitation. Still she didn't move her feet and her shoulders, though stiff with defiance, remained hunched, her gaze affixed to the floor.

Lance felt sick.

Lance felt angry.

Lance felt—

Lance paused that line of thinking, and took a deep steady breath. He could be upset later. It was time for Catra now.

Slowly, he came around his desk and crouched to be closer to the girl's height, leaving plenty of space between them and a clear path to the door. "Catra? Catra, could you look at me please?"

The magicat said nothing but after a moment slowly raised her head to look at him with wary, mismatched eyes.

"Catra, I know you're incredibly intelligent. And I think you were enjoying the book quite a bit. So much so I'm sure you would have done the homework. Can you tell me what happened to your assignment?"

The girl scowls at the ground for a long time. “I got in trouble. Sir.” She finally mutters. “I was in solitary until this morning.”

Lance let all the implications of the statement, both said and unsaid, wash over him and before asking, “Would you like to study here?”

Catra blinked, once, twice. “Here?”

“In the classroom.”

Wide eyes narrowed in wary confusion. “Why?”

Because it’s the slightest bit safer in here than out there. “Because I know it can be annoying and distracting out there, and maybe it’ll be easier to avoid trouble away from all that.”

Catrra daringly searched his eyes for several moments. Then she gave a seemingly uncaring shrug. “Yeah, okay.” The loosening of her tail from her leg and the slight upturn of her ears belied her devil-may-care demeanor.

Lance smiled. “Okay, then. Dismissed. We’ll let this assignment go so you don’t fall behind. Just…in the future, please don’t take your squadmate’s assignment for your own.”

Catra gives a quiet snort, seeming to surprise even herself, before she snaps a quick salute and scurries out the door. As it slid shut, Lance caught a flash of her bushy mane being joined by a pittering bundle of golden locks and couldn't help his smile.

So. it turns out that glasses don’t freaking exist in the Fright Zone.

Were the kids supposed to just shoot at the blurs that weren't grey and red?

Wait. Don't tell him.

Lance wearily put it on another supply request and when the next class started he just slipped his own onto Rogelio's desk. He knew his material enough to not need them, even if there were times he had to squint at the worn buttons on the advanced yet equally shoddy projector.

The prescription was clearly off—Rogelio balanced them moreso his nose than anything and kept delicately adjusting them but he didn't strain his neck and squint his eyes the whole class and at the end, separate from the newest pile of papers, they were left on his desk, neatly folded.

Lance didn't make it a habit of distressing his students—it was the antithesis of what he believed in. It was the worst thing a teacher could, to take a safe space and pollute it.

Therefore he shouldn't have found squad D1's antics funny. But.

The sheer horror on Catra's face as Lonnie drolly acted out Mr. Darcy proposing to Adora's Ms. Bennet was…

Privately, it probably didn't help that the girl had pulled the role of Mr. Bingley to Kyle's *other* Ms. Bennet the day prior.

Lance *finally* manages to get Adora to sit down to discuss her work.

It in no way should have been as difficult as it was, but ever since she'd attacked him, Shadow Weaver had seemingly been encouraging (read: forcing) Adora to do "remedial lessons" which apparently had less to do with actual education, and more to do with grueling physical drills.

Lance had been trying to plot a way to get her even briefly out of the witch's clutches, but Catra beat him to the punch, forcibly dragging Adora back into her seat as she made to leave with the rest of the class and keeping her still with a firm grip on her ponytail.

"Catraaa!"

"No."

"Yes."

"Nope."

"..."

"..."

"...ugh, fine. But Shadow Weaver won't be happy."

"She never *is* ." Still, satisfied with Adora's compliance the magicat gently detangles her claws from Adora's golden locks and stretches out the best she could in her bolted chair, flopping her tail into a delighted Adora's lap in a silent apology

Catra had swiftly taken Lance up on his offer and seemed to consider the classroom a sort of safe haven, and her appetite for literature proved to be voracious to boot. Lance didn't want to have her read to far ahead, but curious, he handed a worn compilation of Billy Javelinshivers' finest works and once she finished her homework, he was delighted to see she slowly poured over the dusty with a carefulness that seemed beyond her years, ensuring her claws were sheathed as she tenderly turned the pages.

Adora, Lance was relieved to see, wasn't disgruntled or belligerent by her low scores. If anything she was sheepish and embarrassed, her usual bravado stripped away in the presence of Catra and an adult to reveal a student eager to please. Almost too eager.

Lance files yet another set of implications away from the moment, already knowing they will haunt him in the confines of his tiny room.

Instead he goes over Adora's last assignment, and feels his trepidation slowly become replaced by a sense of confusion. Adora has difficulty reading, it was clear but with her writing she seemed almost baffled by some of the corrections Lance made and the errors he pointed out.

"I…don't get it," she confessed an hour in, rubbing her neck awkwardly.

Lance frowned, gazing at her writings, at the way the letters in the words alternated between the Common alphabet and various strange, branching and interconnected lines—

Wait.

"Adora," Lance said, doing all he could to keep the anxiety from his voice, even as his heart began to pound. "Can you read this?"

On a spare sheet, he etched out the constellation-like lines and starry dots he knew by heart.

Adora squinted at it, brow furrowed in slight confusion. "It says 'lunch'."

Lance blinked. "It does?"

Catra craned her head. "It does?"

Adora gave a decisive nod. "It does."

It sticks with him that night, the momentous understanding, the sheer implication of what he's learned today.

Adora can read the First One's script.

He'd tested her a few other words he and George had relative understanding of and she understood each of them without fail.

Lance had believed Shadow Weaver's insistence on silencing the children's former instructors regarding Adora's problems had been done for her own vanity, the refusal to have one of her personal wards be considered an academic failure. And while he had no doubt that that was a major reason, he also was willing to bet that the witch understood that there was an untapped gem sitting

in her lap and was determined to ensure that Adora's apparently inherent ability stayed firmly in her grasp.

Even ignoring the history and culture, the First Ones had left a wealth of technological marvels behind, some even capable of making the Horde's advanced technology seem crude and rudimentary. Even just having someone able to read the *labels* could prove invaluable. And if Hordak discovered this, he could very well order the girl removed from Shadow Weaver's "care".

George would love them. Lance knew he would. Adora's eagerness, Catra's growing bibliophilic tendencies, Lonnie's fond snarkiness, Kyle's nervous enthusiasm, Rogelio's stoic attentiveness.

And what about the way Mitch tried to do different character voices when he read. Or the way Ren couldn't help but doodle along her the sides of her sheets. Or the shy way Uma looked at him under her lashes to ensure she was pronouncing her words correctly. Or…or…

Two dozen children, bright, eager, intelligent children. Growing up with pain as their old friend and guns in their hands. Children who would grow up only to be sent to a battlefield. Again and again, to kill or be killed.

And, oh! His husband. Would he ever see him again? Would he grow old, sitting alone on their anniversary? Or would he remarry, find love once more, and have Lance become yet another old ache, forgotten until he couldn't be anymore.

What about their sons? Would they remember him? Would they find peace? Or would they grow up with heart's full of vengeance for the Horde, for the people who seemingly killed their father.

Would the children he raised and the children he taught one day meet on one of those bloody battlefields, intent on slaying the other, unknowing of the tenuous connection that existed between them?

He turns about in his uncomfortable bunk, seeking solace in sleep even as his heart leaked his pain past sealed lids.

He's delighted to find, as they wrap their first novel, that while not all of his requested materials were acquired (or if they were, didn't pass muster), they did at least grab one of the most important ones and he gladly takes copies of relevant sheets and passes them out.

"Class, our next unit will be on the Etherian Signing Standard language!"

Lance isn’t surprised that Rogelio picks it up, or even Kyle, but Lonnie is also a quick study that rivals even the lizardman himself, her fingers moving in quick abbreviations with the skill that rivals a pro. Lance remembers her file, that her parents had actually

been Hordesmen, that she had been one of the few brought into the creche before she’d become an orphan and wonders. Still he’s proud of her, especially when she’s gracious enough to help a struggling Krom.

Adora's attempts interest him. She keeps adding in strange new ones into her sequences, only seeming to notice when Catra points it out. It makes his fingers itch for a pen. They'd never come across any form of guide for First Ones sign language, though of course they'd suspected that the ancient people had to have had one, or even several. With Adora seemingly having a built-in dictionary for the script that was overriding her written Common, it made sense that she'd have another preset meant to overlap with the language in other forms as well.

Still despite his curiosity, he had to be cautious. More than once, when he was going over Adora's work after class, the rest of her squad and a handful of others having joined to lounge about and do their own assignments, he'd catch a glimpse of something shifting at the corner of his eye. The first time he believed it was a trick of the light, the second time he suspected, and by the third, he knew with crystal clarity. Shadow Weaver was living up to her name, skulking about with that dark, icy magic of hers, covetously watching over her blonde investment. He had a feeling the children knew or at least suspected as well—more than one he'd caught a glimpse of a student raising their head, back stiff, eyes darting about and heads craning, or else falling quiet and bending closer to their desks, shoulders hunched. More than once Catra's fur had ruffled and risen, and her ears and tail would begin twitching and lashing frantically.

It was yet another injustice to swallow, another lump of anger to quell, to know that the witch terrorized his students, to know that

this room, this place of learning, could not be safe no matter how he tried.

One of the food foundries has a massive fire. Four days later, a second has to shut down after its machinery, accelerated sixty percent to compensate for the first loss, utterly breaks down, the poorly maintained pistons and struts utterly falling apart.

Top personnel are reduced from the option of three or four bars a meal thrice a day to six bars for the entire day. Standard soldiers get shrunk to four daily. Lance, having been considered something of a mix between a prisoner and indentured servant over the last eight months, is reduced from six bars a day to three, along with the older cadets.

The younger children get one.

The moods in the class range from apathy to irritation to perpetual exhaustion. They stare listlessly at their novels and worksheets. Lance reduced their assigned work on the first week. By the second week, the already lean kids are leaner still, and he disregards work entirely in favor of quietly and slowly reading aloud from their current novel, pretending not to notice when some put their heads on their desks, struggling to retain their strength. Despite the food shortage, it seemed as if the children's drills had not reduced—if anything they'd grown in intensity.

The Horde relished the notion of strength. And this was an impromptu culling. The weak would not continue.

Hunt doesn't come to class one day. When Lance checks the attendance record on hispacd, the child's name is nowhere to be seen. Erased, as if he'd never existed.

Hunt's twin, cruelly named Runt, seems to shrink in his own skin. His already lean frame became nearly skeletal. His squad tries to rouse him when class ends and he drags his feet, eyes hollow with hunger and grief, the remains of his squad protectively flanking him. Lance stops the leader, Jag, and slips her his dinner bar, ignoring his own grumbling stomach to flick his eyes at Runt meaningfully. She gets the message, her own exhausted gaze tightening in determination.

Runt lasts four more days before his name disappears from Lance's list.

(He hears whispers, from both the children and gossiping soldiers, all trying to distract themselves from their slow starvation, that a cadet, wrapped in two blankets, had slipped past the guard bots and night patrols, only to get a bolt in the back from the border guards as he staggered across the desert towards the Woods.)

(He spends two weeks painstakingly carving *Hunt* and *Runt* into the metal frame of his bunk with a broken washer. He carves their names, their ages and surrounds it with a wonky heart and a terribly scratched series of tiny carved flowers because he knows not if they're finally at peace, but he won't let them be two more

chewed up and forgotten in a place so ugly, lifeless and terrible. It was far too late, but they deserved to have all the pitiful beauty Lance could conjure.)

Lonnie falls when she's trying to get up after class and her squad surrounds her, warily gazing at the other students, who gaze at them with the gleaming hunger of wolves.

(This is how the Horde turns children into fodder. It turns them against each other, turns them into barely concealed beasts, eternally starving.)

"Class dismissed," Lance says firmly. "Lonnie, please stay for a moment."

Lonnie looks betrayed, her squad appalled. It was lunch time, now their sole meal of the day. Lance looks at Adora, who was puffing up, fists clenched and jaw stiff, firmly in the eye. *I will not harm her,* he says with a look, *she is safe with me.*

The blonde hesitates before slowly, reluctantly signaling to her team who troop after her with the rest of the class, casting anxious looks back over their shoulders.

Lance waits until they're gone before approaching Lonnie, whose defiant gaze slackened in shock as he hands her his lunch and dinner bar. "Here. Nibble on them slowly."

She shows remarkable restraint, carefully but quickly slipping one bar into her pocket, hunching her body slightly as if to prevent him from taking it back. She tears the paper wrapper away, and proceeds to take slow, deliberate bites, seemingly counting her chews before each swallow.

Lonnie is young, but determined and proud, and so Lance does not ask about her rations (because she and Rogelio split their already minuscule amount he knows, giving it to Kyle, who like Hunt and Runt seems to have a faster metabolism and is already too skinny and they would do it anyway, but especially now and especially because Adora cannot bug them not to in lieu of giving her own rations to her fellow blonde because she needs to save it for when Catra, punished for some falsehood or another, gets released from solitary for the night.) He doesn't ask if she needs to rest (they always do).

Instead he asks, "May I help you with your dreadlocks?"

Because he recognizes the way the hair has started to unravel, the way it has started to loosen but its owner hasn't the time or energy to devote her attention to it. Because he mourns the lack of familiar heft on his head. Because when he closes his eyes at night, he can almost feel the sun on his back and smell the sap in the air as a fragment of his heart nestles against his knees, working his fingers through strands of hair like his father and his father's father before him.

She hesitates but acquiesces and so he spends over half an hour pouring tiny amounts of water on a desk and stands behind her with wet-tipped fingers, gently but firmly doing his best to smooth out knots and rework the twist as she finishes the bar and carefully eats half of the other, wrapping the remains of it up and away with the sacred care only children can seem to achieve.

By the time the food crisis is resolved and the portions are back to normal, two more children have died, their names vanishing from the record (but not his, he **won't** let them be erased). The mood is subdued even more than usual, tiny shoulders stiff with resignation and pain, with experience of blows of all kinds raining down on them, gaining an immunity to them.

(Except that's a lie, you never become immune to such wounds and the ones that do are the ones that tend to grow up to fill the shoes of the monsters that tormented them.)

It's a risk. It's foolish. Lance doesn't care. He writes those four names upon the board and tells the children they will be having a moment of silence and if anyone wants to write something nice on the board, they could do so.

They gaze back at him with baffled eyes. Hadn't they heard of giving respect to the fallen? Hadn't they ever been encouraged to grieve?

(Of course they hadn't.)

"But," Jag says cautiously, searching for the ulterior motive, the hidden test. "Cadet 2201 was a traitor."

" *Runt* ," Lance gently corrects, "was your peer. A friend." *As were Hunt and Yaps and Stanley.*

Jag doesn't respond to that, but five minutes into their vigil she determinedly stands, walks the board and writes, *You were a traitor, but I'll miss you.*

Shadow Weaver strides into his classroom as bold as brass one day and lingers behind him, no doubt waiting for him to halt his lecture and give her his attention.

Lance doesn't bother, continuing to speak with little more than a hitch to indicate he even noticed her walk in. If she wants acknowledgement, she could use her manners like everyone else. Even children knew how to raise their hands.

The next twenty minutes are spent with Lance speaking to a nervous, wide-eyed classroom ping-ponging their gazes between the calm Lance and an increasingly irritated Shadow Weaver.

Finally, the witch grows impatiant and flexes her power, seeping threatening darkness into the room like a leaking gas pipe.

(Lance practically knows the story of Elinor and Edward like the back of his hand. He could keep going, he has no doubt.)

(He eyes the way Adora moves herself to slightly block the witch's veiw of Catra, even as the magicat leans forward, claws biting into the desk, tail lashing, ears back and soul ready to have her best friend's back, and he closes his book.)

"Commander Shadow Weaver," he say, the height of geniality, "A pleasure to see you."

George had often teased him for being too honest. Oh, if he could see Lance now.

Shadow Weaver gazed at him with a familiar gleam in her masked eyes and he felt his heart quicken.

"I simply wished to see what your vaunted lessons were like. After all, *Prisoner* , you have been entrusted with a vital part of the education these cadets will need. As Head of Training, I am, of course, curious.

"And yet," she sneers, "I walk in to see not cadets working hard but a teacher treating them like *infants* . Reading aloud to them

as if this was a lights out lullaby! These are soldiers, not children. And while some cadets may be suited to such *coddling* ," she turned her gaze briefly upon Kyle, who quailed and the anger within Lance's heart flared, "you dare to hold back those with the greatest potential? As a, dare I say, fellow instructor, I—"

"You are no fellow of *mine*, witch, and *how dare* you call yourself a *teacher*."

The class audibly gasps, and Shadow Weaver's eyes flare.

He blinks. Once. Twice.

Twitches his finger, wiggles his toes and licks his parched lips with an oversized tongue. He's on the floor, the classroom ceiling above him and Shadow Weaver is talking.

To his class.

"—a reminder. Never forget a person's origins. This is a Rebel, and it is your job to sort out the facts from his accidental and purposeful propaganda—"

"Excellent point, Shadow Weaver," Lance says, with all the steadiness he can muster, even as he uses his desk to haul his way up and sweat beads on his brow, even as his heart pounds

unsteadily, even as his legs tremble with all the grace of a newborn fawn. "We may make an adequate teacher of you yet."

He stands as straight as he can and stares her straight on. *I dare you,* he says with his eyes, *I dare you to. Try again. You'll have to kill me before I falter.*

Shadow Weaver's greatest weakness he's noted, besides herself of course, is her thought that everyone else was just as selfish and cruel and vain as her. It was an attitude that worked well in the Horde but caused nothing but rage when it met someone like Lance, when it lashed out only for its target to refuse to relent.

Because, see, Lance has fought this sort of monster before. Not with blades and magic, but pens and paperwork and a steely gaze. He knows this sort of creature that stands before him, the type that loathes their own inadequacies and lashes out at the helpless, who rages at the notion of defiance. He has seen these kind, the ones who dress like people and try to pretend that they are, that everyone is just like them even as their souls fester with blackened hate and putrid greed. Lance has faced these polished beasts and will face them as many times as it took, because sometimes all it took was someone saying "no" and sometimes all it took was someone willing to get back on their feet after being knocked down.

Shadow Weaver's presence expanded for a moment, darkening the room, but when Lance stood steady, it abruptly receded. The witch glared at him, her eyes nearly glowing in fury, before she whipped around and glided out the door in a way that still managed to look like storming.

"Well," Lance said after a moment. "Hopefully there will be no more interruptions." He picked up his book with unsteady fingers. "Where were we?"

"Mr. Lance?"

"Hmm?"

"Are you okay?"

Lance paused his flipping through the book to gaze at his children. Almost two dozen small faces gazed back at him and though his sight was a bit blurry, his glasses perched as usual upon Rogelio's face, he could still see the naked concern mirrored on all of them.

No, he wasn't okay. He was a prisoner. He missed his family everyday. His room was terrible, the food was awful, his sleep abysmal.

And yet…

He looks at this class of children, who dare to show a stranger empathy in a place designed to root it out and crush it as soon as possible. He looks at the children, these curious and inquisitive souls, who months earlier did little more than shuffle in and sit at

reluctant military precision. He looks at these kids who've grown (in height, in confidence, in personhood) before his eyes, and so almost doesn't lie when he smiles and says, "I am."

"—belligerent, disrespectful and insidious! He seeks to undermine the Horde, starting with it's most vulnerable members! My Lord, his influence must be culled before it's too late!"

Hordak, lounging on his throne with a datapad in hand, stared down at Shadow Weaver for a long moment before his crimson gaze slid over to the silent Lance. "Is this true Rebel?" He said boredly.

Weaver gives a quiet gasp of affront, and Lance struggles to keep a grin off of his face. "No, sir."

"Hmmm." Hordak tapped his datspad. "By all accounts Commander, this Rebel has increased productivity and literacy rates in his class. Drill Sergeant Cobalt has reported an increased speed in terms of map, direction and order reading. The teaching of Etherian Signing has increased cadet squad efficiency." He leaned forward, now glowering at the witch. "I see no reason to remove the prisoner from his post."

"But My Lord—!"

"ENOUGH! Cease your prattling complaints, Shadow Weaver. My decision is final. Do not bother me with this again."

Shadow Weaver says nothing for a long moment. Then, she sketches a bow and stalks out of the throne room, briefly meeting Lance's eyes and glaring at him as she passes.

Lance swallowed. This wasn't over yet—he could feel it. A witch like her wouldn't get to where she did without contingencies for barriers and Lance had no doubt that he had become one.

Two days later, in the dead of night, he is awoken by the whoosh of his door opening. He doesn't even have time to lift his head before rough hands grab his arms and legs with bruising force. He's forcibly yanked out of his cot and manhandled through the door and into the corridors. He tries to turn his head to speak to his captor and receives a dizzying smack for his troubles.

His shoulders ache as they're pulled and stressed by the half-nelson he's stuck in, and his toes ache and bleed as his bare feet trip and smack into the rough and icy floors. It's a painful twenty minutes of traversing sparsely populated halls and what seemed to be service corridors and Lance, despite his terror, finds his curiosity beginning to peak over the circuitous route.

Eventually they lug him out of a service elevator and into a massive hanger bristling with skiffs of all sizes. The soldiers ignore

the numerous engineers dotted about bur Lance can feel their eyes on them, hear the way lazy conversation becomes silent.

Finally, after pulling him into a side bay, they drop him on the deck of a parked skiff and Lance feels his heart sink when he glimpses the familiar red robes.

"Leave us."

The soldiers hastily take their leave and Lance pushes himself up, eyeing the witch warily. She sat regally upon one of the skiff's tiny seats, looking at him with a calculating gaze. The bay was dark save a single sickly green bulbs, and her already shrouded features were shrouded further with shadow, save her eyes which flowed with cruel magic.

"I apologize for the rough treatment Dr. Lance, but appearances must."

The usage of his title startles him more than it should. He hadn't been called that in *years* .

Shadow Weaver seems to take his surprise as a sign of encouragement. "I believe we got off on the wrong foot, Doctor. I have read over your work and it is quite impressive, all things considered." She pauses for effect. "Would you like to continue it? Perhaps, in a more familiar setting?"

Lance's pounding heart stopped. "What are you saying?"

"I'm saying," Shadow Weaver crooned. "That I am willing to release you from your indenture."

Lance scowled, stood. "Just like that, huh?"

"Just like that."

"And Hordak allowed this?"

In the gloom, he saw her fist clench briefly, before smoothing out. "Hordak's opinions will not matter much to you, especially once you've gone to reunite with your family." She rose and glided towards him. "Isn't that what you've wanted all these months? To be free? You've completed your service." A shimmer of shadow and a key appeared in her pale hand. This skiff is loaded, fueled and ready to go. The border guards have been told to expect a vehicle coming through in the next hour. It can carry you at least to the Whispering Woods. You can make your way from there."

The key glinted, a siren's song. He could go home. Smell the sap outside his door, eat to his heart's content, sleep on his soft bed and shower with water that wasn't ice cold. He could read his books, traverse his favorite stories with tea in hand, walk to the market whenever he wished.

He could see his sons again. Could see them laugh and grow. Watch as they found education, experience, themselves, love. And George. He could snuggle in George's strong arms, giggle at the feel of his husband's mustache brushing his ear as he crooned love songs into the quiet evening.

His fingers twitched, his arm started to raise. He could go *home* . He could—

His hands still.

What about the children?

He doesn't realize he's said it aloud until Shadow Weaver tilts her head and scoffs, "What about them?"

What…about them?

What about Adora's progress in reading and writing? What about feeding Catra's bibliophilia? What about stoking Kyle's confidence? What about Rogelio's eyesight and mutism? What about giving Lonnie the attention she deserves?

And who would provide a set of instructions for Krom to peruse when the speed of speech overtook him? Who would let Percy

spend a half hour or so resting because their headaches were flaring up again?

(Who would remember the names so callously erased?)

If not me, then who?

Something in Lance's face seems to clue Shadow Weaver in, as before he can blink, her already hovering hair behind to lash about, the dim lighting grows dimmer still and she's looming over him, eyes narrowed in fury, and icy pale hands curled like claws towards his face. He stumbles back, against the rigging and she follows his path, a twisted creature of nightmares.

" *Don't be a fool,* " she hisses, her voice layers with the hints of something cruel and otherworldly. " *This is your only chance! Fail to capitulate and I will see you trapped in the darkest mines of Etheria! I will have you flayed until you are nothing but bloodied skin! I will —*!"

Lance has always been lucky. A hard worker, yes, but also *lucky* .

Or perhaps, one might say that the land, unbalanced as it was, was always seeking to correct itself, and with all the cruelty and evil in the world, the good managed to shine all the brighter.

So whether it is Lance's luck or the planet's karma, in the end what matters is this:

Seeking distance from the horror before him, Lance steps back, only to stumble over the rudder and sail controls. He lands heavily on them, and with nary an inch to spare between his nose and the rigging strut, the whole thing lurches, swinging forward fast and hard.

A hard *crack!* and a *thump!* and a muffled gasp sounds as Shadow Weaver, feared Witch and Second of the Horde, is hit straight in the face with the heavy sail and sent flying clean off the skiff to smash into the bay wall and slide to the floor, mask cracked and askew and out cold.

Lance spends a good five minutes laying on the skiff, trying to steady his racing heart. Then he painfully crawls to his feet and off the vehicle and slowly, cautiously makes his way over to Shadow Weaver's slumped over form.

The crystal in her mask is cracked, and a nasty split runs down the porcelain surface. He carefully grasps her bony wrist and sighs in relief as he feels the slow thudding of her beating black heart. Of course that doesn't diminish his growing terror.

All it takes is her waking up and reporting the incident and either way, he's done for. No one would believe that she'd set him up, no one believe that the SiC of the Horde being knocked out was an accident, he'd be locked in the mines or executed before morning, he'd never see his family again, his students would—

He pauses. Eyes the key still grasped in the witch's hand. Feels like an idea to start to grow. It's a stupid idea, but then…he's already doomed.

He breathes, once, twice. In for a copper, in for a crown.

"Hey, Adora? Catra?"

"Mmrrph?"

"Hmmm?...Mr. Lance?"

"Hey, kids? Want to go on a field trip?"

His heart is pounding. It shouldn't be this easy.

But apparently the night guards were all but asleep, the patrol bots were easy to evade, and the hangar engineers took one look

at his stolen officer's badge and decided to once again ignore him, even as two dozen sleepy but eager cadets trailed after him.

Skiff keys were apparently one size fits all as to his relief, the large transport skiff starts up easily when he inserts it. He stares helplessly at the far more complex dashboard but Kyle helpfully points out the pedal layout, Adora harks vehicle safety and points out the hanger door opening signal, Catra and Lonnie fight briefly over the gear control before Catra contents herself with controlling the turret (wait, what?) and Rogelio breaks into the lone crate in the back, which is apparently someone's ration bar stash, and starts passing them around.

It's an unsteady start, but Lance is a quick learner and it takes only a handful of quick swerves and overcorrections (the children cheering dutifully in the back) for him to figure it all out and drive across the desert, the Fright Zone proper growing smaller behind them. They pass the border patrol without pause and while they are suspicious, no one bothers to say anything. A vehicle *was* expected to pass through after all.

(Twenty minutes later, they pale as Shadow Weaver's furious voice roars through their communications. The Fright Zone goes on lockdown and it takes almost an hour of confusion and conflicting orders before a small skiff platoon is sent out after the wayward prisoner and the stolen cadets.

By the time they reach the transport tracker's location, all they find is the empty truck and ration bars wrappers littering the ground about the treeline.)

("Mr. Lance?"

"Yes, Kyle?"

"...do we…do we have to go back?"

"If you don't want to? Never."

"...can we stay in your home?"

"If you want to? Forever.")

George smiles as his boys dutifully clear the table. His eyes grow wet as his gaze slides toward the plate on his left, the one that never leaves the table, in front of the chair never sat in. The seat still waiting for its owner's return.

He starts to rise himself but pauses as the doorbell rings. He glances at the clock. It's nearing nightfall. A flicker of unease runs down his spine.

"Now who can that be?"

He leaves his plate and walks towards the door, carefully treading the soft carpet and instinctively avoiding the spots that squeaked. He palms his wrist dagger and cautiously opens the door a crack. "Who is it?"

"Hello!"

The youthful voice gives him pause before he opens the door wider. His eyes widened at the veritable sea of children wearing Horde iconography on his doorstep, all gazing at him with expressions ranging from curious to cautious.

"Excuse me children."

George's breath catches.

Like an angel descending from the heavens he watches a taller figure emerge from the dusk gloom and begin wading their way through the living ocean of young bodies. Any thoughts about their clothing or their presence all but disappears as his personal seraphim emerges for the first time in a year from his dreams to his reality.

His hair is shorter and greyer. His body is thinner. His clothes are too big and filthy, his feet bare.

But his eyes…oh, his eyes.

They're tired and older and haunted but they're warm and brimming with tears and love as they get closer and before long George is reaching forward with a trembling hand, releasing a broken sob as a familiar callused finger intertwines with his own.

"Is this real?" He chokes, vision blurring as tears drip down his face. "Please let this be *real* ."

Lance comes closer, wrapping his skinny arms about George's neck, his poorly shaved stubble tickling the former soldier's chin, his familiar warmth seeping into his body, his heart, his *soul* .

"I'm real," Lance whimpers into his ear. "I'm real, love."

George grips him tight, wishing more than anything to become one, to never let him go again. "You're alive. You're *home* ."

"I'm home." Lance smiles against his neck even as tears drip past his collar. " *We're* home."

George is abruptly reminded of their young (and incredibly patient) audience and releases a shaky laugh as he tucks Lance under his arm and gazes at their blurred forms with an enormous grin. "Welcome home!" He cries, gesturing at the open door and warm light spilling out onto the forest floor. "Welcome all!"

For a moment there's nothing. And then a tiny blonde girl with enormous blue eyes and an adorable tiny ponytail squares her shoulder and steps forward, an equally adorable magikitten shadowing her instantly. And with that, the lost children of the Horde step forward into their new lives.

Lance leans back onto his knees, George's steady presence at his back. He closes his eyes, inhaling the peaky scent of decaying leaves on the autumn breeze, savors the warmth of the gentle sunlight on his face and the raucous sound of children around the house as his sons teach the former cadets games to play that the young would-be soldiers take to with zeal.

He reaches back down and trails his fingers over the letters of the newly arrived bronze plaque and the stone base it was affixed to: *In memory of Hunt, Runt, Stanley and Yaps. May their souls fly free.*

(He swore he would not forget, that they would not be forgotten. He keeps his promises.)

He shivers as the slightly cooler breeze sends goosebumps across his skin, and immediately there's a warm and heavy afgan wrapped about his shoulders and his husband is helping him to his feet and curling against him with a gentle smile. With one last look at the plaque, they begin to walk around the house, following the calls of the kids.

In a day or two a Brightmoon representative was scheduled to arrive, both to debrief Lance and discuss how to help the newly freed children. Come spring, they would plant a sapling at the plaque base—apple, perhaps—that would grow tall and strong and wise and that the young and old would pluck fruits from and remember.

But for now, he leans against the love of his life, plots how to create thirty plus cups of cocoa and lets the precious sound of children's laughter soothe the lingering aches of his soul.

End Notes

So yeah, this inspired by Discord, has been buzzing in my head for a bit, because we never really seem to get stories about Lance or George as people beyond their status as Bow's dad.

So not my best work, true, but I had fun with it and I hope you did too.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!